Class 10 SST - Chapter 22: Consumer Rights

🌟 Introduction to the Chapter

We participate in the market both as producers and consumers. As consumers, we have rights to protect ourselves against unfair trade practices and exploitation by sellers.

📌 The Consumer Movement

The consumer movement arose out of dissatisfaction of the consumers as many unfair practices were being indulged in by the sellers.

- There was no legal system available to consumers to protect them from exploitation in the marketplace.
- In India, the consumer movement originated as a 'social force' to protect and promote the interests of consumers against unethical and unfair trade practices (like rampant food shortages, hoarding, black marketing, and adulteration of food).
- This culminated in the enactment of the **Consumer Protection Act 1986** (popularly known as COPRA).

⚡ Rights of Consumers

COPRA provides for the establishment of consumer dispute redressal agencies at the District, State, and National levels for the protection and promotion of consumer rights.

1. **Right to Safety:** Right to be protected against the marketing of goods and delivery of services that are hazardous to life and property.
2. **Right to be Informed:** Consumers have the right to be informed about the particulars of goods and services that they purchase (ingredients, price, batch number, expiry date).
3. **Right to Choose:** Any consumer who receives a service in whatever capacity has the right to choose whether to continue receiving the service.
4. **Right to Seek Redressal:** Consumers have the right to seek redressal against unfair trade practices and exploitation. If any damage is done to a consumer, they have the right to get compensation.
5. **Right to Represent:** COPRA enabled us to have the right to represent in consumer courts.

❌ Common Mistakes to Avoid

> [!WARNING]
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> 1. **Consumer Forums vs Courts:** Consumer forums (or consumer protection councils) are voluntary organizations that guide consumers on how to file cases in consumer courts. They are not the courts themselves.
> 2. **RTI Act:** Do not confuse COPRA with the Right to Information (RTI) Act of 2005. RTI ensures its citizens all the information about the functions of government departments.

📝 Quick Revision

Taking the Consumer Movement Forward

India is one of the few countries that have exclusive courts for consumer redressal. December 24 is observed as National Consumers' Day. However, the consumer redressal

process is becoming cumbersome, expensive, and time-consuming. Consumer awareness forms the backbone of making these rights a reality.